THE LAST SIGNAL

Interactive Mystery Game — Story, Puzzles & Development Notes

An organized and proofread version of the supplied game concept. Spelling, grammar, punctuation, and formatting have been improved while preserving the original plot, clues, passwords, and intended player experience.

DESIGN DOCUMENT • VERSION 1

Contents

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• Basic Game Requirements

Note: The original draft contains a few gameplay details that may need a final consistency check (for example, the call duration and the number of seconds of dialogue). These have not been silently changed.

Stage 1 — The Archived Files and the Exorcist’s Letter

Story setup

When players enter the website, they discover archived case files relating to the real Zodiac Killer case. They also find a password sheet, but ink has obscured some of the passwords.

Password sheet

• **Map:** Password not readable

• **Archive:** 17046849

• **Audio Evidence:** 1908

• **Witness Files:** Password not readable

• **Suspect Database:** Password not readable

• **Cipher Terminal:** SEVENMARKS

• **Restricted Dossier:** Password not readable

Password reminders

• **Map:** The password is a house number.

• **Suspect Database:** Use the same password as the previous website.

There will be six documents related to the five murder cases identified among 37 other unidentified cases, as well as the Exorcist’s Letter.

On closer inspection, players notice a sticky note attached to the Exorcist’s Letter.

Puzzle — Sticky note

The sticky note contains the following text:

```
Zyper t1ue nbshg oi5rsussc
-kythe uwlwlhfa tryera
cojowhfogh pfjpwj ;gjgs
apfjwpjw glegl giwigppe
sjojgooheig 34hohg-1
ejgpgp jgkakhgle johfa7
```

Solution

• Taking the first letter of each line reveals: **Z-K case**.

• Taking the last letter of each line reveals: **case-17**.

Combining the two results gives the login details.

Developer instructions

When players append **Z-K case-17** to the main website URL, a new section containing locked files appears.

• **Username:** Z-K case

• **Password:** case-17

Stage 2 — The Locked Documents and the Coordinates

Story setup

Players discover four locked documents about the Zodiac Killer case that were not included among the earlier files. It appears that someone deliberately left the username and password for them to find, raising the question: why were these documents locked?

Puzzle — Photo details

Each document contains a photograph with three details:

• Date

• Time

• Location

The photographs show the victims, and each location indicates where the victim was killed. One photograph uses letters in place of the location coordinates.

```
Encoded coordinates: (CG.GHHGD, -LB.DEG I)
Intended decoded coordinates: (37.78874, -122.45709)
```

Solution

When players search the decoded coordinates on Google Maps, they find house number **3893**. This number becomes an important clue later in the game.

Stage 3 — The Witness Testimony and the Map

Story setup

The third document, whose location is given as CG.GHHGD, -LB.DEG I, contains the following witness testimony.

CASE FILE 017 — WITNESS TESTIMONY

Location: House 3893, San Francisco
Subject: Unidentified resident
Incident referenced: The death of Paul Stine
Status: Unverified recollection

Interview transcript

DETECTIVE: Tell us what you remember from that night.

WITNESS: Not much, I’m afraid. It was late. I remember being inside the house when something outside caught my attention. I couldn’t tell you exactly what it was. A sound, perhaps. A door closing. Something that made me look toward the window.

DETECTIVE: Did you see anyone?

WITNESS: No. It was too dark. I could make out shapes along the street, but nothing I could confidently identify as a person. I remember a car, though I can’t swear to its colour or how long it was there.

DETECTIVE: And the incident involving Paul Stine?

WITNESS: I learned what had happened afterward. At the time, I didn’t understand what I might have been hearing. There was no clear view from where I stood, and I never went outside to investigate.

DETECTIVE: Did you hear a voice?

WITNESS: Perhaps. That's the trouble with memories like these. Once you've heard the stories, you begin to wonder whether you remember the night itself or merely everything you've been told about it since.

DETECTIVE: Is there anything else you recall?

WITNESS: One thing. I remember a light in a window across the street. It went out, and for a moment the whole street seemed completely still. I can't tell you whose window it was. I can't even tell you whether that happened before or after I heard the sound.

DETECTIVE: So you cannot identify anyone?

WITNESS: No. I saw nothing clearly enough to identify anyone.

END OF TESTIMONY

Investigator's annotation: The witness provides no direct identification and cannot establish a reliable sequence of events. The recollection may be influenced by information learned after the incident. Further corroboration is required.

EVIDENCE STATUS: INCONCLUSIVE

Puzzle and solution

The document contains testimony from someone who lives at house number 3893. That house number is the password needed to unlock the Maps section, as hinted at on the original password sheet.

Map locations

• Lake Herman Road, Benicia, California

• Blue Rock Springs Park, Vallejo, California

• Lake Berryessa, Napa County, California

• Washington and Cherry Streets, Presidio Heights, San Francisco, California

Developer instructions — Killer's message

As soon as players unlock the map, they receive the following message from the killer:

> *"This is Zodiac speaking.*
>
> *You have 24 hours to discover where I will strike next.*
>
> *Solve my clues. Find the location. Entertain me.*
>
> *If you're right, I'll call it off. Of course, I can't risk being caught.*
>
> *If you're wrong, another name will be added to your case files.*
>
> *The clock is ticking.*
>
> *Let's see if you're as clever as you claim to be.*
>
> ***24 HOURS. ONE LOCATION. ONE CHANCE.**"*

The message includes a link to a video file. Players must choose one of the four locations on the map, and they have only one chance to make their choice. If they choose incorrectly, they will not discover the result until 24 hours of real-world time have passed.

Stage 4 — The Reversed Audio and the Suspicious Call

Puzzle — Audio clue

The video linked in the previous message plays a recording of the killer speaking:

> *“Four locations. One has been chosen. Three are irrelevant. You have twenty-four hours to tell me which one. Don’t mistake this for a game, detectives. I know you’ve been studying my words, searching for patterns, convincing yourselves that every little detail brings you closer to me. But what happens when your instincts fail you? When the clock reaches zero and you realize you sent your attention to the wrong place? Choose carefully. I won’t give you a second chance. One wrong answer. One more name on your list. Tick-tock, detectives. Someone is counting on you.”*

While the killer speaks, the audio includes beeps that may lead players to suspect Morse code, along with other background noises.

Solution and audio-production notes

When the audio is reversed, it reveals the coordinates of the location.

• Take two audio clips.

• Reverse the clip containing the hidden message and overlay it onto the main clip.

• Add background noise so the hidden audio is not immediately obvious.

```
Target coordinates: 37.78857° N, 122.45605° W
```

Outcome after 24 hours

After 24 hours, players receive a new message. If they chose the wrong location, the killer mocks them, saying he was only joking this time but that next time will be different. If they chose correctly, he sends a mocking congratulations message and explains that he only wanted to divert their attention.

The director’s suspicious-call message

At the same time, the director sends the players a message. He says he has received a suspicious call and asks them to investigate its transcript. He does not know that the call is connected to the Zodiac Killer case; he sent it for a different reason.

Players notice that the call lasted 47 seconds, while the dialogue accounts for only 30 seconds. They must investigate what happened during the unexplained portion of the recording.

Puzzle — Morse code

The audio accompanying the transcript contains beeps that form a Morse-code message. When decoded, the message reads: “YOU ARE NEXT TO DIE.”

This clue is intended only to frighten the players; it does not lead to another clue. When the two-day timer ends, a new murder occurs. The recruits learn about it directly from the killer, who sends them a newspaper article about the incident.

Stage 5 — The Newspaper Reports and Suspect Database

In-game newspaper article — October 23, 2026

THE SAN FRANCISCO CHRONICLE

OCTOBER 23, 2026 | CRIME & PUBLIC SAFETY

NEW VICTIM FOUND IN SUSPECTED ZODIAC COPYCAT CASE

Anonymous message raises questions about a possible connection to historic killings

SAN FRANCISCO — The body of 34-year-old archivist Daniel Mercer was discovered Thursday night in a disused office building near the Presidio. Police have not confirmed a connection to the original Zodiac Killer cases.

Mercer had recently been cataloguing historical records. A colleague claims he had grown concerned about inconsistencies in archived documents.

“He said someone was changing the records,” the colleague reported. “Not destroying them. Changing their meaning.”

Hours before the discovery, an anonymous message was reportedly received: “You were looking at the wrong person.” Beneath it was a symbol resembling seven short marks.

Investigators have not confirmed the message’s origin or whether the killing is connected to the historic case.

AN UNSETTLING DISCOVERY

A document recovered from Mercer’s office reportedly carried conflicting creation and modification dates. Its contents remain undisclosed.

The investigation is ongoing, and authorities urge the public not to rely on unverified online claims.

EDITOR’S NOTE: This article will be updated as verified information becomes available.

Second newspaper article — October 24, 2026

THE SAN FRANCISCO CHRONICLE

POLICE INVESTIGATION | OCTOBER 24, 2026

POLICE REOPEN INQUIRY FOLLOWING NEW ZODIAC-RELATED KILLING

Investigators examine an anonymous website containing historical case files and unexplained messages

San Francisco police have expanded their investigation into the recent killing of archivist Daniel Mercer, following reports of an anonymous website containing documents connected to the original Zodiac Killer case.

The website contained four archived case files, encrypted messages, audio recordings, and brief witness statements whose origins remain uncertain.

Investigators are attempting to determine who created the site and whether its contents were intended to mislead authorities or reveal information withheld from the public.

A police spokesperson stated that the authenticity of the material had not yet been established.

THE WEBSITE’S LAST ACTIVITY

Records indicate that the website displayed a new message shortly before becoming inaccessible.

Examiners have not determined whether the message originated from the original creator or someone who gained access afterward.

Stage 5 — The Newspaper Reports and Suspect Database (continued)

The website’s last activity

Officials are also investigating an unusual sequence of characters discovered within the archived records. The sequence appears to have been inserted into otherwise ordinary text.

Police have declined to disclose the sequence publicly, citing the ongoing investigation.

Encrypted files remain inaccessible, and no suspect has been officially identified.

Evidence recovered from the victim’s office is still under examination. Documents related to the website have been transferred to a restricted archive.

Authorities have urged anyone with verifiable information to contact investigators.

END OF REPORT

Solution — Suspect Database

The solution is **Z408_REOPENED**. This is the password for the Suspect Database.

To reach the database, players append **suspect-database** to the main website URL, similar to how the Archive section was accessed previously. A password screen appears, and players enter the password they have just discovered.

Stage 6 — The File That Should Not Exist

Story setup

After Daniel Mercer's discovery, another person contacts the investigators claiming to have found a second copy of the altered records. The person is later found dead in a locked room. The recovered papers point toward Ellen Vale and provide the clue needed to unlock Stage 7.

Developer instructions — Opening message

DIRECTOR — 02:13 AM

Daniel Mercer was not the only person who noticed the alterations.

Someone contacted us last night claiming to have another copy of the records Daniel was investigating.

We were supposed to meet them today. They never arrived.

The police have recovered a folder from their room. I have uploaded its contents.

One thing bothers me. The final page is dated tomorrow.

Please examine the documents carefully. Do not assume that everything in this folder was written when its timestamp says it was.

Document A — Incident Report 06-B

FICTIONAL CASE DOCUMENT • STAGE 6

Subject: Unidentified source connected to the Daniel Mercer investigation
Status: Deceased; circumstances under investigation

An individual who had recently contacted investigators regarding altered archival records was found dead in a locked room. No clear sign of forced entry was reported. Several papers relating to the Daniel Mercer investigation were found on the desk.

Investigators recovered a torn note, a photograph, and a handwritten page. The individual's identity and the circumstances surrounding the death remain unconfirmed.

Additional observation: The recovered papers include a reference to a document dated October 1971. No explanation for this reference has been established.

Document B — The Torn Note

Recovered from the room:

> "Mercer was right. The records were changed, but not all the copies were changed.
>
> I found the older version.
>
> The answer is not in the names. It is in the dates.
>
> Read what remains. Then look where the record ends.
>
> — E.V."

Stage 6 — Puzzle and Solution

Puzzle — Archive access

A small file named **ARCHIVE_ACCESS.txt** is included with the recovered documents. It contains the following clue:

> “The initials were left behind.
> The year was never erased.
> Put them together exactly as they appear in the record.
> No spaces.”

Solution

The initials on the torn note are **E.V.**. The incident report refers to the year **1971**. Combining the initials and the year, without spaces, gives the password **EV1971**.

Developer instructions — Stage 7 password

Set the password for the Stage 7 file or website to **EV1971**. Players should enter the password to open Ellen Vale’s journal. Keep the answer out of the player-facing clue and show it only in the developer notes.

Suggested password screen

> **ARCHIVE FILE LOCKED**
>
> Enter the archive password to access the next document.
>
> *Hint: The initials were left behind. The year was never erased.*

If the developer cannot add a new password system before launch, use an existing password input or a password-protected file. Avoid adding a new technical feature if the website already has a simple locked-page mechanism.

Final message — Unknown Sender

> You found the copy.
>
> Daniel found it too. The person before him found it.
>
> Do you know what all three of you have in common?
>
> You believed you were investigating the records. You never asked who was keeping a record of you.
>
> **One last thing:**
>
> The file you opened first was not the file I wanted you to find. But now I know which one you chose.

Stage 7 unlock message

> **STAGE 6 COMPLETE**
>
> One name remains: Ellen Vale.
> Open her journal. Examine the dates. The final review is waiting.

Stage 7 — Ellen Vale’s Journal and the Final Review

Story setup

After entering the Stage 6 password, players open Ellen Vale’s journal and the final review attachment.

THE LAST SIGNAL
Research Journal of Ellen Vale — October 1971

I’ve spent years studying the Zodiac Killer’s letters, ciphers, and reported crimes across Northern California.

The Z408 cipher was solved in 1969, yet it revealed no identity. The Z340 cipher remained unsolved, and every new letter brought more questions than answers.

I’ve separated verified evidence from public speculation, but the same question persists: who was the person behind the name?

The newspapers call this an investigation. I call it an unfinished puzzle.

Perhaps the answer lies in a detail everyone overlooked.

Until then, the files remain open.
Researcher: Ellen Vale
Attachment found: FINAL_REVIEW.mp4

Video sequence

When players click the attachment, a video opens. It shows a recording of the website, including the password sheet, the Exorcist’s Letter, and the first locked documents. The footage then advances, showing the clues the players solved, one after another: the coordinates, the witness testimony, the audio recording, and the suspicious call.

Every clue has already been catalogued in a document titled EXPECTED INVESTIGATOR RESPONSES. The document contains three possible interpretations for each clue, including theories the players formed when they became stuck. Someone had anticipated the possible outcomes of the investigation.

The video displays a final page:

> “You have tried very hard to find the killer…
> But did you ever think about what would happen if he tried to find you?”

The video ends. Immediately afterward, the director sends the following messages:

> The case is closed.
>
> You have done enough.
>
> Delete your local copies of the files and wait for further instructions.

After opening the messages, players can no longer click any buttons on the screen, as though the website has frozen. When they refresh the page, only one article remains.

Stage 7 — The Final Article

THE SAN FRANCISCO CHRONICLE
POLICE & CRIME | OCTOBER 24, 2026

POLICE RECRUIT FOUND DEAD INSIDE STATION
Internal investigation launched as questions emerge over Zodiac case files

SAN FRANCISCO — A police recruit was found dead inside a San Francisco police station late Thursday night, prompting an immediate internal investigation.

Authorities have withheld the recruit's identity pending notification of the family. The circumstances surrounding the death remain unclear, and officials have yet to confirm whether foul play was involved.

According to sources, the recruit had recently been assisting officers with the examination of historical documents connected to the infamous Zodiac Killer case.

Investigators are now reviewing station records and interviewing personnel who were present that evening. Police have not confirmed whether the recruit's work had any connection to the incident.

"We are examining all available evidence and will release further information when appropriate," a department spokesperson stated.

The investigation remains ongoing. Authorities have urged the public to avoid spreading unverified claims while the circumstances are being established.

No further details have been released at this time.

As players reach the end of the article, a video begins. It shows the bodies of the recruits, followed by a distorted image of the Zodiac Killer just before the video ends.

Basic Game Requirements

- The game will run for 14 days and contain seven stages.
- Players will have a 48-hour timer to complete each level. If they fail to complete a level before the timer expires, they will receive no points for that level.
- The game will include a built-in chat box through which two characters—the killer and the director—can send one-way messages to players.
- Players can earn extra points for guessing the correct location in Stage 4.

Editorial consistency checks

• The suspicious-call section says the call lasted 47 seconds and the dialogue lasted 30 seconds, leaving 17 seconds unexplained. The original draft also asks what happened during “those 7 seconds”; confirm which duration is intended.

• The draft refers to both a 24-hour timer and a two-day/48-hour timer. Confirm which timer applies to each stage.

• The opening section mentions six documents related to five identified cases and 37 unidentified cases, while later sections refer to four locked documents. Confirm whether these are separate groups of files.

• The target coordinates and the encoded-coordinate clue have been preserved as supplied; verify that each points to the intended in-game location before launch.